Weekly Assignment: Research Question and Outline

MSCD Pre-Thesis - Fall 2026

Part 1. The three steps

Step 1: Topic

I am studying how adult Chinese Gen Z understand their own role and the role of digital systems in everyday life. I focus on three forms of digital systems: super apps, generative-AI chat, and emerging AI agents.

Step 2: Question

I want to understand what people still want to do themselves, what they are comfortable doing together with a system, and what they are willing to let a system do for them. I also want to understand when people notice that a system has already shaped these roles.

Step 3: Significance

I want to help interaction design and HCI audiences understand how people’s expectations of their own role change when a system shapes daily routines, joins knowledge work, or acts on their behalf. This understanding can later help designers decide how a system should show, explain, and allow people to reshape these roles.

Part 2. Canvas discussion post

Topic: Human–System Roles in the Digital Lives of Chinese Gen Z

My research is about how adult Chinese Gen Z understand their relationship with digital systems. I focus on three forms of technology: super apps, generative-AI chat, and emerging AI agents. They represent three different ways that a system can enter everyday life. Super apps organise many daily activities in one place. AI chat can take part in searching, writing, and thinking. AI agents may go further by making plans or acting for a person.

How do adult Chinese Gen Z understand and negotiate the roles of people and digital systems when super apps shape everyday routines, generative-AI chat participates in knowledge work, and emerging AI agents act on a user's behalf?

This question comes from something I find difficult to explain in daily life. I often think of an app as a tool that I choose to use. However, the tool also teaches me how to use it and sometimes changes what feels normal. For example, I may need a phone and a platform account to pay, communicate, travel, or receive a service. I may use AI to develop an idea, but later feel unsure about which part of the thinking was mine. In the future, I may ask an AI agent to act for me, but I may not want the same level of delegation in a job application, a private conversation, and a food order.

Many studies of human–AI interaction examine one task, such as writing, drawing, or decision-making. Other studies offer useful principles such as transparency, explanation, correction, and user control. My question is connected to this work, but it starts one step earlier. I want to ask how people understand the role a system already has, and what role they want to keep, share, or give away.

The new part of this study is the comparison of the same question about roles across three different system arrangements. I will not treat each technology as a separate design problem. I will compare how participants' boundaries change when a system shapes a routine, joins their thinking, or takes action for them.

The Chinese context matters because systems such as WeChat are connected to communication, payment, services, work, and institutions. For many young adults, using these systems is not always a simple personal choice. At the same time, I will not try to cover every part of Chinese Gen Z life. I will study the larger question through three selected arrangements: super apps shaping everyday routines, AI chat participating in knowledge work, and AI agents acting on a user's behalf.

I will use Research through Design and develop three connected design probes. They will place participants inside specific situations and ask them to make choices, explain their reactions, and revise the roles given to the person and the system. The goal is not to teach participants that technology is bad or that people should always have more control. I want to learn where different participants draw boundaries, why they draw them, and how those boundaries change across situations.

This research is relevant to interaction designers, HCI researchers, and teams designing platforms or AI systems in China. The possible outcome is a set of situated findings, a revised model of human–system roles, and design considerations for making these roles easier to notice, discuss, and reshape.

Part 3. Working thesis outline

1. Introduction

- Introduce the change from super apps to AI chat and AI agents.
- Explain the main problem: systems do not only complete tasks; they also shape the roles available to people.
- Explain why adult Chinese Gen Z is the selected group.
- State the research question, scope, and expected contribution.

2. Research context and literature

- Super apps as everyday infrastructure in China.
- Human agency and human–system roles.
- Generative AI as a participant in knowledge work.
- AI agents, delegation, and responsibility.
- Existing principles for human–AI interaction.
- Reflective design, design probes, and Research through Design.

3. Conceptual framework

- Define a role as what a person or system is expected and allowed to do.
- Compare three system arrangements: shaping routines, participating in knowing, and acting for a person.
- Present the initial assumptions without treating them as final answers.

4. Methodology

- Recruit adult Chinese Gen Z participants.
- Conduct short early interviews about real experiences with platforms and AI.
- Develop and pilot three design probes.
- Collect choices, observations, participant comments, and post-probe interviews.
- Analyse each probe first, then compare patterns and differences across the three.

5. Design probes

- *Evil PM Simulator*: how platform decisions become part of everyday routines.
- *Epistemic Illusion*: how AI takes part in thinking and knowledge production.
- *Cyber-Utopia Persona Quiz*: what happens when an AI agent is allowed to act for a person in simple and difficult situations.

6. Findings

- How participants describe their own role and the system’s role.
- What they want to keep, share, or delegate.
- When they accept, question, resist, or revise a system arrangement.
- Differences between everyday routines, knowledge work, and delegated action.
- Cases that challenge the starting assumptions.

7. Discussion

- Answer the research question using findings from all three probes.
- Revise the initial human–system role model.
- Explain what is specific to the Chinese context.
- Compare the findings with existing human–AI design principles.
- Develop situated design considerations rather than universal rules.

8. Conclusion

- Summarise the main findings and contributions.
- Explain the limits of the participant group and the probe method.
- Identify questions for later research and other cultural contexts.